ANSWER KEY & MARKING SCHEME — ENGLISH LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE · CLASS X · SET 01

Max. Marks: 80 · Alternative correct answers / expressions to be given due credit · Writing: Format 1 + Content 2 + Fluency & accuracy 2

SECTION A — READING SKILLS — 20 marks

1. Read the following passage. **10**

1. Millets are small-seeded grasses that Indian farmers have grown for thousands of years. Ragi, bajra, jowar, kodo and many other varieties once formed the everyday meal of villages across the dry regions of the country. Grandmothers prepared rotis, porridges and dumplings from them without calling them anything special. Today, nutrition experts have given the group a fashionable new name — 'nutri-cereals' — and the humble grain is slowly returning to the dining table, the school kitchen and even the restaurant menu.

2. The decline of millets was not an accident. After the Green Revolution, public policy focused on increasing the production of wheat and rice. Farmers received seeds, fertiliser and assured purchase prices for these crops, while the cheap rations distributed through the public system also consisted mainly of rice and wheat. Millets were gradually seen as the 'poor man's food', something to be eaten only when nothing better was available. As incomes rose, families proudly shifted to polished rice and refined flour, and the area under millet cultivation shrank year after year.

3. Scientists now argue that the shift was costly. Millets are rich in dietary fibre, iron, calcium and other minerals, and they release energy slowly, which helps in controlling blood sugar. They are also remarkably hardy crops. They need far less water than rice, grow on poor soil, tolerate heat and seldom need heavy chemical fertilisers. In a time of erratic rainfall and rising temperatures, a crop that survives where others fail gives small farmers a valuable measure of security.

4. Recognition of these strengths has come from several directions. The United Nations declared 2023 the International Year of Millets after a proposal by India, drawing global attention to the grains. State governments have included millets in school meals, and self-help groups run millet cafés and sell ready-to-cook mixes. New processing machines remove the tough outer husk quickly, reducing the long hours of labour that once made millet cooking tiresome. As a result, young urban consumers who never tasted these foods are discovering them as tasty and convenient.

5. Challenges remain. Many people still prefer the softness of polished rice, millet products can cost more than ordinary cereals, and farmers need assured markets before they will risk planting them again. Yet the return of millets is not an exercise in nostalgia. It is a sensible response to the twin problems of poor nutrition and a changing climate. A grain that was once dismissed as humble may well prove to be one of the wisest choices a hungry and warming world can make.

Created for academic usage / 421 words

Answer the following questions, based on the passage above.

I. Why were millets once regarded as the 'poor man's food'? (Paragraph 2) **1**

> Because government policy, subsidies and rations promoted wheat and rice, so millets came to be seen as an inferior food eaten only when nothing better was available.

II. According to Paragraph 3, millets are valued for all of the following EXCEPT **1**

(A) their fibre and mineral content
(B) their ability to grow on poor soil
(C) their low need for water
(D) their dependence on heavy chemical fertilisers

> **Ans: (D)** Millets seldom need heavy chemical fertilisers.

III. Complete the following by selecting the correct option from those given in the brackets: Millets can survive difficult weather conditions because they are _____ crops. (hardy / delicate) (Paragraph 3) **1**

> hardy

IV. Select the option that is TRUE for the statement 'The United Nations declared 2023 the International Year of Millets' (Paragraph 4). **1**

(A) Millets were introduced to India in that year.
(B) Global recognition drew attention to the grains and encouraged their wider use.
(C) The declaration banned the cultivation of rice.
(D) The declaration was made without any proposal from India.

> **Ans: (B)** Global recognition drew attention to the grains and encouraged their wider use.

V. Complete the analogy by selecting the correct option. **1**
Wheat and rice : Green Revolution support :: Millets : _____

(A) Present-day awareness campaigns
(B) Colonial trade policies

> **Ans: (A)** Present-day awareness campaigns (millets are now being promoted through campaigns and school meals).

VI. How do processing machines and millet cafés make millets more acceptable to modern consumers? (Paragraph 4) **2**

> Machines remove the husk quickly, so the long labour of preparation is reduced (1); cafés and ready-to-cook mixes make millet foods tasty and convenient for young urban people who never tried them (1).

VII. What are the main ideas of Paragraph 2 and Paragraph 3? **1**

i. Millets lost popularity because policy and prestige favoured wheat and rice.
ii. Millets offer better nutrition and need fewer resources to grow.
iii. Millets are costly and difficult to cook.
iv. Rice and wheat are unsuitable for Indian farmers.
v. Millets can be grown only in the dry parts of Rajasthan.

Option	Main idea of Paragraph 2	Main idea of Paragraph 3
A	iii	iv
B	i	ii
C	ii	i
D	v	iii

> **Ans: (B)** Paragraph 2 — i; Paragraph 3 — ii.

VIII. Why does the author describe the return of millets as 'a sensible response' and not as 'nostalgia'? (Paragraph 5) **2**

> Because millets solve present problems — poor nutrition and an unpredictable climate (1); they are chosen for their health benefits and resilience, not just for sentimental attachment to the past (1).

2. Read the following passage. **10**

1. A survey of 600 students of Classes 9 to 12 in a large city examined how much sleep young people get on school days. The findings were worrying. Nearly 78% of the students (468) said they slept for fewer than eight hours, while only 22% (132) slept for eight hours or more. Further, 54% (324) admitted that they used their phones within half an hour of going to bed, and 42% (252) reported difficulty in concentrating during the first two periods of the day.

2. The survey also tried to find out why students sleep so little. About 31% (186) pointed to late tuition and coaching classes, while many others mentioned unfinished homework and the habit of watching videos at night. Interestingly, among the 132 students who slept for eight hours or more, only 20 students (about 15%) reported poor

concentration in the morning, compared with nearly half of those who slept less. This suggests that sleep and attention in class are closely linked.

3. Educators recommend that students follow a fixed sleeping schedule and keep phones away at least thirty minutes before bedtime. Schools can help by planning homework sensibly and starting important lessons when students are most alert. Sleep is not a waste of study time; it is the foundation on which learning is built.

Created for academic usage / 215 words

Answer the following questions, based on the passage above.

I. Why do the survey findings suggest that lack of sleep is widespread among students? (Paragraph 1) **1**

> Because 78% (468 out of 600) of the students slept for fewer than eight hours on school days.

II. Complete the following by selecting the correct option from those given in the brackets. Since 468 of the 600 students slept for fewer than eight hours, getting less sleep is _____ among them. (common / rare) (Paragraph 1) **1**

> common

III. Select the option that best explains the expression 'difficulty in concentrating' in Paragraph 1. **1**

(A) Students cannot attend school.
(B) Students find it hard to keep their attention on lessons.
(C) Students dislike the first two periods.
(D) Students are unable to complete homework.

> **Ans: (B)** Students find it hard to keep their attention on lessons.

IV. Complete the following with the correct option. The comparison of students who slept eight hours or more with those who slept less suggests that **1**

(A) sleep has no effect on learning.
(B) sleep and attention in class are closely connected.
(C) only older students need sleep.
(D) tuition classes improve concentration.

> **Ans: (B)** sleep and attention in class are closely connected.

V. Complete the analogy by selecting the correct option. **1**
Sleep : Alertness :: Late-night screen use : _____

(A) Distraction
(B) Concentration

> **Ans: (A)** Distraction / fatigue (screen use at night disturbs rest).

VI. Complete the following appropriately. The fact that 324 students used their phones near bedtime suggests that screen use may be one reason for _____. (Paragraph 1) **1**

> their late sleeping hours / reduced and disturbed sleep

VII. How can a fixed sleeping schedule benefit students? (Paragraph 3) **1**

> It makes the body used to regular rest, so students wake up refreshed and more attentive.

VIII. Why does the author say that sleep is 'not a waste of study time'? (Paragraph 3) **1**

> Because well-rested students learn and remember better; sleep supports the learning process itself.

IX. Suggest two ways in which schools can help students to sleep better. Explain how this would help in the long run. (Paragraph 3) **2**

> Plan homework sensibly / avoid overloading (½); begin important lessons when students are alert (½); long run: healthier, more attentive students who perform better and keep better habits (1).

SECTION B — GRAMMAR AND WRITING SKILLS — 20 marks

GRAMMAR — 10

3. Complete any ten of the twelve of the following tasks, as directed. **(10 × 1 = 10)**

I. Fill in the blank by using the correct form of the word in the bracket for the given portion of a museum guide: **1**

The old fort has been beautifully _____ (preserve) so that visitors can understand the city's history.

> preserved

II. Identify the error and write the correction in the given sentence. **1**

She is senior than me by two years.

ERROR	CORRECTION

> Error: than — Correction: to (she is senior to me).

III. Fill in the blank with the correct form of verb given in the brackets. **1**

By the time the guests arrived, the cooks _____ (prepare) the meal for two hours.

> had been preparing

IV. Read the given statement. **1**

The principal said, “We will announce the results next week.”

Report it correctly by completing the following.

The principal said that _____.

> they would announce the results the following week.

V. Fill in the blank by choosing the correct option. **1**

The speaker's talk drew attention _____ the need to conserve water.

(A) to
(B) at
(C) on
(D) over

> **Ans: (A)** ‘draw attention to’.

VI. Report the following by completing the sentence correctly. **1**

“Please lend me your notes,” Mohan requested Rita.

Mohan requested _____.

> Rita to lend him her notes.

VII. Complete the given sentence by filling the blank with the correct option. **1**

The coach encouraged the players _____ harder before the final.

(A) to train
(B) training
(C) trained
(D) train

> **Ans: (A)** encourage + object + to-infinitive.

VIII. The given sentence has an error. Select the option that correctly identifies the error and the correction. **1**

Neither of the two bags were damaged during the journey.

No.	Error	Correction
A.	Neither	Either
B.	were	was

C.	damaged	damaging
D.	journey	journeys

Ans: (B) 'Neither' takes a singular verb: were → was.

IX. Report the following question. **1**
The guard asked the visitor, "Where are you going?"

The guard asked the visitor where he was going.

X. Fill in the blank with the correct option from those given in the brackets. **1**
The library is still closed, so the books _____ (cannot / should) be borrowed today.

cannot

XI. Fill in the blank to complete the sentence in a teacher's diary by choosing the correct option. **1**
_____ students in the hall remained silent when the results were announced.

(A) Much
(B) Every
(C) Most
(D) Little

Ans: (C) 'Most' is used with plural countable nouns.

XII. Identify the error and write the correction in the given sentence. **1**
The furniture in the new office are very comfortable.

ERROR	CORRECTION

Error: are — Correction: is (furniture is uncountable and takes a singular verb).

4. Attempt ANY ONE from A and B. **1 × 5 = 5**

A. You are Rhea/Rohan, a resident of Shanti Nagar. Garbage has not been collected from the lane near your school for over a week, causing a foul smell and health risk. Write a letter to the Municipal Commissioner of your city, in about 120 words, drawing attention to the problem and requesting immediate action.

Format (1): sender's address, date, receiver, subject, salutation, close. **Content (2):** problem, effects on students/residents, request for daily collection/inspection. **Fluency (2).**
Sample: 14, Shanti Nagar, Jaipur / 12 March 2027 / The Municipal Commissioner, Jaipur / Subject: Irregular collection of garbage near Green Valley School. Sir, I wish to draw your attention to the heaps of uncollected garbage in the lane near Green Valley School, Shanti Nagar. For nearly a week no vehicle has arrived. The foul smell, stray animals and swarms of flies make it difficult for students to concentrate and may spread diseases such as dengue and diarrhoea. Residents and parents are deeply worried. I therefore request you to arrange immediate clearance, install covered bins at the corner and ensure daily collection in future. Your prompt action will protect the health of hundreds of children. Yours faithfully, Rhea Sharma.

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B. You are Kanika/Karan of Class X. Noise from loudspeakers used during late-night functions in your locality is disturbing students during their board-exam preparation. Write a letter to the Editor of a national daily, in about 120 words, highlighting the problem and suggesting practical remedies.

Format (1), Content (2), Fluency (2). Points: loud music after 10 pm, stress and sleeplessness, health effects, legal limits, suggestions — fixed time limits, police action, community awareness.
Sample: The Editor, The Daily Voice, New Delhi / Subject: Noise pollution during examination time. Sir, through your esteemed newspaper I wish to bring to public notice the nuisance caused by loudspeakers at late-night functions in our locality. Music often continues beyond midnight, depriving students of rest and concentration at a time when examinations are near. Elderly people and patients also suffer from stress and sleeplessness. The law clearly restricts loudspeakers after 10 p.m., yet the rule is rarely enforced. I request the authorities to check violations strictly, and organisers to adopt sound limits and shorter schedules. Residents too must show consideration. Such small steps will keep our neighbourhoods peaceful. Yours truly, Kanika Verma.

5. Attempt ANY ONE from A and B. **1 × 5 = 5**

A. Aditi/Aman is the Cultural Secretary of a school and has to choose a captain for the school quiz team. **Neha:** well-read, quick at recall, leads discussions confidently, but gets nervous on stage and often loses marks in rapid-fire rounds. **Kabir:** calm under pressure, excellent in rapid-fire and buzzer rounds, but his general knowledge is limited and he rarely prepares in advance. Based on the profiles, analyse and decide who would be the better captain. Consider teamwork, preparation, performance under pressure and leadership. (100–120 words)

> **Content (2):** comparison of both profiles with a reasoned decision; **Organisation (1)**; **Fluency (2).** Either choice is acceptable if justified.
> *Sample:* Both candidates bring strengths to the captaincy, but Neha appears the better choice. Her wide reading and ability to lead discussions can help the team prepare thoroughly, and a captain must guide teammates before the contest as much as during it. Kabir is calm in rapid-fire rounds, yet his limited preparation could weaken the team's overall performance and set a poor example. Neha's nervousness on stage is a weakness, but it can be reduced through practice and the support of teammates. Since Kabir's calmness can be used effectively by making him the lead buzzer-round player, the team gets the best of both. A captain who prepares, plans and encourages ensures lasting success, so Neha should be chosen.

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B. The table compares two study apps.

Features	App A	App B
Monthly fee	₹199	₹349
Practice questions	5,000	12,000
Doubt-solving	Chat, 24 hours reply	Live video, 2 hours reply
Offline access	No	Yes
Average user rating	4.1 / 5	4.5 / 5

Study the data and write an analytical paragraph in about 100–120 words comparing the two apps, identifying their strengths and limitations and suggesting which is better for a Class X student, with reasons.

> **Content (2):** accurate use of data from the table; **Analysis/recommendation (1); Fluency (2).**
> *Sample:* App B offers more than App A, but at a higher price. It has 12,000 practice questions compared with 5,000, provides live video support with a reply in two hours and works offline, which is useful where internet is unreliable. Its higher rating of 4.5 suggests greater user satisfaction. App A is cheaper at ₹199, yet its chat support takes up to 24 hours and it cannot be used offline. For a Class X student preparing for board examinations, quick doubt-solving and a large question bank are more valuable than saving ₹150 a month. Therefore App B is the better choice, although students with a tight budget may begin with App A.

SECTION C — LITERATURE TEXTBOOK — 40 marks

6. Read the following extracts and answer the questions for any one of the given two, (a) or (b). **5**

(a)

> *When the hail finally stopped, the field that had been so green and full of promise lay white, as though a heavy layer of salt had been spread over it. Lencho stood silently among the broken stalks. His heart was heavy, but he told himself that the loss was not the end of everything, because there was still one source of help he could trust completely.*
>
> (A Letter to God — extract adapted)

I. What did the field look like after the hailstorm? **1**

(A) green and fresh
(B) white, as if covered with salt
(C) dry and cracked
(D) flooded with water

> **Ans: (B)** It looked white, as if covered with salt.

II. State one inference about Lencho from the given extract. **1**

> He is a man of deep faith / he is hopeful even in distress.

III. Fill in the blank. The comparison of the field with 'a layer of salt' suggests _____. **1**

(A) a good harvest
(B) complete destruction of the crop
(C) a change of season
(D) unexpected beauty

> **Ans: (B)** complete destruction of the crop.

IV. How does the extract show the contrast between Lencho's earlier hopes and his present situation? Answer in about 40 words. **2**

> Earlier the ripe, green field promised a good harvest (1); now it is destroyed and he is left only with his faith in God (1).

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(b)

> *On the day of the inauguration, the amphitheatre in Pretoria was packed with leaders from many nations and ordinary South Africans of every colour. Sitting there, the speaker was filled with a sense of history, remembering the long years in which people of his race had been denied the most basic rights. He felt that the celebration belonged not to one man but to the entire country.*
>
> (Nelson Mandela: Long Walk to Freedom — extract adapted)

I. Where was the ceremony held? **1**

(A) Cape Town harbour
(B) A stadium in Johannesburg
(C) The amphitheatre in Pretoria
(D) Robben Island

> **Ans: (C)** In the amphitheatre in Pretoria.

II. What does the presence of ordinary South Africans along with world leaders suggest? **1**

> That the freedom was shared by all and was recognised by the whole world.

III. Complete suitably. The speaker felt that the celebration belonged to _____. **1**

(A) his party only
(B) the entire country
(C) the foreign leaders
(D) the military

> **Ans: (B)** the entire country / all the people, not one man.

IV. Why does the speaker recall the 'long years' of denial of rights at this moment? Answer in about 40 words. **2**

> The memory of past injustice makes present freedom meaningful (1); it shows the struggle and suffering that made the day possible (1).

7. Read the following extracts and answer the questions for any one of the given two, (a) or (b). **5**

(a)

> *The speaker says that some people believe the world will end in flames while others believe it will end in freezing cold. From what he has felt of human desire, he favours those who say fire. But if the world had to perish a second time, he thinks that hatred is so destructive that ice would do the job equally well.*
>
> (Fire and Ice — paraphrased)

I. Which two elements are compared in the extract? **1**

(A) Earth and water

(B) Fire and ice
(C) Wind and rain
(D) Sun and moon

> **Ans: (B)** Fire and ice.

II. What does 'fire' stand for in the poem? **1**

(A) Hatred
(B) Desire
(C) Calmness
(D) Hope

> **Ans: (B)** Desire / passion and greed.

III. Complete suitably. The poet suggests that hatred is _____. **1**

(A) harmless
(B) equally destructive as desire
(C) less powerful than love
(D) temporary

> **Ans: (B)** equally destructive as desire.

IV. How does the speaker use the two possible ends of the world to warn about human emotions? Answer in about 40 words. **2**

> Fire and ice are natural destroyers (1); they represent desire and hatred, showing that uncontrolled emotions can destroy humanity as surely as nature (1).

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(b)

> *A boy has lost his ball, and it has bounced away and drifted into the water. The poet watches him and decides not to console him with the offer of a new ball. He understands that a replacement cannot take away the true loss. The boy must learn through experience how it feels to lose something he loves and how to stand up after it.*
>
> (The Ball Poem — paraphrased)

I. What has the boy lost? **1**

(A) his toy
(B) his ball
(C) his money
(D) his friend

> **Ans: (B)** His ball.

II. Why does the poet not offer to buy a new ball? **1**

> Because a replacement cannot teach the boy about loss and responsibility.

III. The poet suggests that the boy is learning _____. **1**

(A) how to play
(B) how to face loss
(C) how to swim
(D) how to save money

> **Ans: (B)** how to face loss.

IV. How does the poet's attitude help the boy grow up? Answer in about 40 words. **2**

> The poet allows the boy to feel the loss himself (1); this experience teaches him to bear misfortune and take responsibility, which is part of growing up (1).

8. Answer any four of the following five questions in 40–50 words each. **(4 × 3 = 12)**

I. How does Anne Frank's diary help her to deal with loneliness in hiding? (From the Diary of Anne Frank)

> Anne treats the diary as a friend 'Kitty' (1); she can share thoughts she cannot tell anyone (1); writing relieves her loneliness and records her feelings honestly (1).

II. How does Mij's behaviour in the bath show the writer's growing bond with the otter? (Mijbil the Otter)

> Mij plays happily with water and toys, showing trust (1); the writer enjoys and understands his playfulness (1); the playful companionship builds affection between them (1).

III. How does Bholi's education change her from a timid girl into a confident woman? (Bholi)

> At school her teacher's kindness gave her self-confidence (1); she learned to speak clearly and value herself (1); later she boldly refuses an unfair marriage and chooses to serve as a teacher (1).

IV. What does Mathilde's reaction to the loss of the necklace reveal about her character? (The Necklace)

> She is honest enough to replace it (1) but also proud and unwilling to reveal the truth (1); her vanity brings years of hardship and shows the danger of false values (1).

V. How does the Buddha teach Kisa Gotami that death is inevitable? (The Sermon at Benares)

> He asks her to bring mustard seed from a house where no one has died (1); she finds none (1); she realises that death comes to all and accepts her loss (1).

9. Answer any two of the following three questions in 40–50 words each. **(2 × 3 = 6)**

I. How does Hari Singh's decision at the end of the story show the power of trust? (A Thief's Story)

> Anil's trust in him moves his conscience (1); he feels guilty of betraying such trust and changes (1); thus trust becomes stronger than punishment (1).

II. What price did Griffin pay for becoming invisible? (Footprints Without Feet)

> He became isolated and lonely (1); he could not live normally, faced hunger and cold (1); he turned to theft and lost others' trust (1).

III. How does the Martians' misjudgement of the book save the earth? (The Book That Saved the Earth)

> Noodle misreads a nursery rhyme book as a warning of Earth's might (1); the Martians fear the supposed danger (1); they retreat, so a simple misunderstanding saves the earth (1).

10. Answer ANY ONE of the following two questions, in about 100–120 words. **(1 × 6)**

(A) Mandela and Lencho both face a severe test. Compare how courage and faith help them respond to hardship. (Nelson Mandela: Long Walk to Freedom / A Letter to God)

> **Points:** Mandela endured imprisonment yet kept his faith in freedom; Lencho lost his crop yet kept faith in God; both refuse to give up hope; Mandela's courage is public and collective, Lencho's faith is personal; Lencho's faith is partly naive (he doubts the post-office staff), Mandela's is tested and informed; both show resilience. (6 = 2 comparison + 2 text reference + 2 expression)

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(B) 'Fire and Ice' and 'The Ball Poem' deal with emotions in different ways. Compare how each poem presents the effect of strong feelings. (Fire and Ice / The Ball Poem)

> **Points:** Frost shows desire and hatred as destructive; Berryman shows grief as a way of learning; one warns, the other consoles through understanding; both treat emotions as shaping human life; each uses simple imagery. (2 + 2 + 2)

11. Answer ANY ONE of the following two questions, in about 100–120 words. **(1 × 6)**

(A) In 'Bholi', education changes the main character's life. Discuss how the story shows the power of education in building confidence and independence. (Bholi)

> **Points:** Bholi's early neglect and stammering; the teacher's encouragement; her growing courage; refusing the dowry-seeking groom; becoming a teacher and caring for her parents; message — education empowers women.

(2+2+2)

O R

(B) 'The Necklace' shows how false pride and vanity can ruin lives. Discuss with reference to the story. (The Necklace)

Points: Mathilde's dissatisfaction; borrowing the necklace for the ball; loss and the debt; ten years' hard labour; irony of the paste necklace; lesson — honesty and contentment; pride prevented a simple confession. (2+2+2)